

HIBISCUS

Hibiscus rosa-sinensis

Quick Facts

Scientific Name	Hibiscus rosa-sinensis
Family	Malvaceae (Mallow family)
Common Names	Hibiscus, China Rose, Shoe Flower, Jaba (Bengali), Gudhal (Hindi), Dasaval (Tamil), Chembarathi (Malayalam), Mandara (Sanskrit)
Native Origin	Tropical Asia; exact origin uncertain — possibly China or India
Colors	Red, pink, orange, yellow, white, peach, and multicoloured hybrid varieties. The deep red single-flowered form is the most culturally significant in Indian Hindu practice.
Height	1 to 5 metres as a shrub; can be trained as a small tree up to 8 metres.
Blooming Season	Year-round throughout tropical India. In regions with a cool winter (northern plains, hills), flowering may reduce between December and February. In Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and other tropical states, the plant produces flowers daily throughout the year. Each individual flower opens and closes within a single day.

Distribution in India

One of the most universally cultivated ornamental plants in India, found in virtually every state. Grown in home gardens, temple courtyards, roadsides, parks, and institutional landscapes from Kanyakumari to Kashmir. Particularly abundant in West Bengal, Kerala, Tamil Nadu, Andhra Pradesh, Maharashtra, and Goa. A sacred plant in Bengali Hinduism, where Jaba (red hibiscus) is offered daily to Goddess Kali and Goddess Durga.

Description and Overview

Hibiscus rosa-sinensis, commonly called the China Rose or simply Hibiscus, is one of the most widely grown ornamental shrubs in tropical and subtropical regions worldwide. The plant belongs to the family Malvaceae and produces spectacular trumpet-shaped flowers of 8 to 15 cm diameter, each lasting for a single day before wilting. The flowers are characterised by a prominent staminal column — a tube formed by fused stamens — that extends well beyond the petals, giving the flower its distinctive brush-like appearance.

In India, the hibiscus is inseparable from Hindu religious practice. The bright red Jaba flower (Hibiscus rosa-sinensis) holds the highest spiritual significance and is the preferred flower offered to Goddess Kali, Goddess Durga, and Lord Ganesha across eastern India, particularly in West Bengal, Odisha, and Assam. In Kerala, the Chembarathi flower is used in Ayurvedic hair treatments and temple offerings to Goddess Bhagavathi. The flower is also offered to Lord Ganesha throughout India as one of his

preferred offerings.

The plant is the national flower of Malaysia, where it is called Bunga Raya, and symbolises courage, life, and rapid growth. It is also one of the state flowers of Hawaii.

Medicinally, hibiscus is of extraordinary importance. The flowers, leaves, and calyx are all used in traditional medicine systems across Asia. The deep red varieties contain high concentrations of anthocyanins, flavonoids, and organic acids. Hibiscus tea (made from the dried calyces of *Hibiscus sabdariffa*, a related species) is consumed widely across Africa and the Americas for its tart flavour and health benefits, including blood pressure reduction.

Blooming Season and Conditions

Year-round throughout tropical India. In regions with a cool winter (northern plains, hills), flowering may reduce between December and February. In Kerala, West Bengal, Tamil Nadu, and other tropical states, the plant produces flowers daily throughout the year. Each individual flower opens and closes within a single day.

Cultivation

Hibiscus is propagated by stem cuttings or, for new varieties, by seeds. Cuttings of 15 to 20 cm are taken from semi-hardwood growth and rooted in sand or cocopeat, ideally between February and June. The plant thrives in well-drained, fertile, slightly acidic soil (pH 6.0 to 6.8) with full sun.

Regular pruning — cutting back by one-third after each major flush of flowering — promotes dense bushy growth and continuous flower production. In West Bengal and other tropical states, hibiscus is pruned heavily in February after the cool season and again in August after the monsoon. The plant is susceptible to the hibiscus mealybug (*Maconellicoccus hirsutus*), which was a severe pest problem across India in the 1990s and required biocontrol intervention.

Uses and Applications

Religious: Red hibiscus flowers are the most commonly used flowers in Bengali Hindu worship, offered daily to Goddess Kali. Used in puja (worship) rituals throughout India.

Hair care: Hibiscus leaves and flowers are ground into a paste used as a hair pack in Ayurvedic treatment. Products containing hibiscus extracts are widely sold commercially for hair strengthening, reducing hair fall, and promoting growth.

Medicinal: Used in Ayurveda for treating hair loss, dandruff, menstrual disorders, fever, and skin conditions. The flowers are used to prepare a paste applied to wounds.

Food and beverage: The calyx of *Hibiscus sabdariffa* (Roselle) is used to make the popular drink Agua de Jamaica in Mexico and Bissap in West Africa. In India, hibiscus roselle is grown in Andhra Pradesh and used for making jam, juice, and herbal tea.

Natural pH indicator: Hibiscus extract changes colour with pH (red in acid, green in base) and is used as a natural indicator in chemistry education.

Interesting Facts

- Each hibiscus flower opens fully for just one day — petals unfurl in the morning and drop by evening, making daily replenishment essential for religious offerings.
- In Bengali Hindu practice, it is believed that offering 1,008 red hibiscus flowers to Goddess Kali on a specific occasion fulfils important spiritual merit.
- The petals of *Hibiscus rosa-sinensis* are used in Asian countries as a shoe polish substitute — rubbing petals on shoes produces a shine similar to black polish, which is why it is called Shoe Flower.
- The hibiscus is one of the few flowers that is equally used in religious, medicinal, and cosmetic applications across South Asia.
- Hibiscus flowers contain mucilage — a gel-forming substance — that thickens preparations and is used in natural hair conditioning masks.

Source: Flower AI Knowledge Base — HIBISCUS entry. Scientific name: *Hibiscus rosa-sinensis*. Family: Malvaceae (Mallow family).